

Briefing: The Escalation of Cloud Insider Threats and Credential Recruitment

Executive Summary

The transition of corporate data and applications to cloud-based platforms has fundamentally shifted the cybersecurity landscape, making individual employees the primary security variable. Current intelligence indicates that threat actors are increasingly bypassing traditional perimeter defenses by targeting the humans who hold cloud credentials. These threats are categorized into three distinct profiles: negligent, manipulated, and malicious insiders. While malicious insiders seeking payment or revenge receive significant attention, data suggests that negligent and manipulated insiders currently represent the highest volume of risk to cloud services. Cybercriminals have industrialized this approach, developing sophisticated "adversary-in-the-middle" toolkits and maintaining active underground markets for stolen session cookies and credentials. To mitigate these risks, organizations must address systemic issues such as "permissions creep" and the lack of centralized visibility over third-party application connections.

Taxonomy of Cloud Insider Threats

Insider risks are classified into three primary categories based on intent and method of exploitation:

- **Negligent Insiders:** Individuals who do not intend to cause harm but create vulnerabilities through poor security hygiene. Common behaviors include password reuse, bypassing multi-factor authentication (MFA), and utilizing unapproved software. This group is identified as the largest source of risk to cloud services.
- **Manipulated Insiders:** Employees who are deceived via social engineering into disclosing credentials or installing malware. This is considered the second most significant threat category.
- **Malicious Insiders:** Individuals who intentionally use their privileged access to steal data or facilitate unauthorized entry for financial gain or personal grievance.

The Underground Marketplace for Access

The cybercrime ecosystem has developed a structured market for credentials, specifically targeting high-value cloud environments.

Credential Harvesting and Resale

Threat actors utilize information-stealer malware to collect saved passwords, session cookies, and service credentials. These are packaged into logs and sold to "initial access brokers," who then provide structured entry into corporate environments. As of May 2026, the most prevalent infostealers include:

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|----------------------------|----|
| Vidar | .1 |
| Stealc_v2 | .2 |
| (ACR (also known as Acreed | .3 |

High-Demand Targets

Market demand is concentrated on credentials and session cookies for critical business and infrastructure services, including

- **Productivity Suites:** Google Workspace, Microsoft 365, Office 365, and Outlook on the web
- **Communication & Infrastructure:** Slack and GoDaddy

Sophisticated Exploitation Techniques

Threat actors use specialized toolkits designed to defeat standard security controls, lowering the barrier to entry for less skilled criminals

- **Adversary-in-the-Middle (AiTM):** These toolkits capture credentials and session tokens in real-time by sitting between the user and a legitimate login page, even during MFA prompts

- **Social Engineering Tactics:** Methods include help desk impersonation, voice phishing (vishing), MFA fatigue (repeatedly prompting a user until they approve), and OAuth consent phishing

- **Automated Exfiltration:** In October 2025, an actor known as "Gold" utilized a custom reverse-proxy technique against Gmail and Okta users, routing stolen data directly to a Telegram bot

Direct Recruitment of Malicious Insiders

Underground forums serve as active recruitment centers for employees with privileged access. In 2025, Intel 471 tracked 41 insider-related posts, ranging from actors seeking insiders to individuals claiming to be insiders offering their services

Notable Recruitment and Breach Cases

Actor Handle	Date	Target/Activity	Outcome/Claim
betway	"Sept 28, 2025"	Salesforce account (Indian company)	Bribed employee for access to 2.3M customer records
Finduser	"Oct 31, 2025"	POS and restaurant systems	Claimed access to 100,000 computers, internal email, and Slack
samsepi0l	"April 4, 2026"	Okta, Slack, and Master Admin access	Auctioned access backed by an insider for 24/7 verification
Gold	Oct 2025	Gmail and Okta	Sold phishing projects using reverse-proxy techniques

Institutional Vulnerabilities in Cloud Environments

Several operational factors exacerbate the risk of insider exploitation

- **Permissions Creep:** Access rights often accumulate over an employee's tenure and are rarely reviewed or revoked, leading to excessive privileges
- **Third-Party Integration:** Employees frequently connect third-party applications to work accounts without oversight, granting these apps visibility into sensitive data
- **Remote Work Dynamics:** The use of personal devices and a decrease in direct monitoring in hybrid environments creates "blind spots" for security teams

Strategic Mitigation Recommendations

To counter the growing threat to the human layer of cloud security, organizations should
:implement the following controls

- Identity Governance:** Conduct regular permissions reviews based on the principle of least privilege and ensure immediate access removal during employee offboarding .1
- Visibility:** Maintain a centralized inventory of all third-party application connections and use tooling to monitor SaaS usage for deviations from baseline behavior .2
- Technical Controls:** Enforce MFA across all platforms, with a specific focus on transitioning toward phishing-resistant authentication methods .3
- Awareness Training:** Invest in specialized training to help employees recognize and report sophisticated social engineering and recruitment attempts .4